Godhuli: The Hour of Seeing (A Collection)

By Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni

The Arranged Marriage (Pgs 14-15)

The night is airless-still, as
before a storm. Behind the wedding drums,
cries of jackals from the burning grounds.
The canopy gleams, color
of long life, many children.
Color of bride-blood. At the entrance
the women have painted the sign
of Laxmi, goddess of wealth, have put up
a blackened pot to ward off
the witch who lives beyond
the ***sheora*** forest and eats
young flesh.

Guests from three villages
jostle, make marriage jokes. A long
conch blast for the groom's party,
men in ***dhotis*** white as ice. Someone runs to them

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with water of rose, silvered betel leaves,
piled garlands from which rise
the acrid smell of marigolds.
The priests confer, arrange wood and incense
for the wedding fire. The chants begin.
Through smoke, the stars
are red pinpricks, the women's voices
almost a wailing. Uncles and Brothers
carry in the bride, her face hidden
under an edge of scarlet silk, her trembling
under the wedding jewels.

The groom's father
produces his scales and in clenched silence
the dowry gold is weighed. But he smiles
and all is well again. Now it is ***godhuli***,
the time of the auspicious seeing.
Time for you, bride of sixteen,
mother, to raise the tear-stained face
that I will learn so well,
to look for the first time into
your husband's opaque eyes.

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INTRODUCTION

These poems pull back the curtain on the traditional South Asian wedding to show the terrifying risks women often face in arranged marriages. How a system built on family honor and "dowry gold" can quickly turn a woman into a prisoner or a victim. It is a chilling progression: a young bride is handed over to a stranger with "opaque eyes," another's value is literally weighed on a scale by her in-laws, her life bartered for social standing. And the third a prisoner in her own home, required to produce only a male heir. It is time for . . .

Godhuli: The Hour of Seeing – A Collection of poems by Chitra Banerjee Divakaruni

Burning Bride (Pgs 57-60)

For the victims of dowry deaths in India

1. In the beginning was fire,
the color of sunrise
through coconut palms,
the color of my wedding sari.
Festive with smell of incense,
the flames flicked playful tongues.
Stumbling to match his unfamiliar gait,
I walked with him
seven times round the fire
while wedding guests threw flowers.

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The whisper of fire, secret, enigmatic,
I hear it
under the ***brahmins'*** rising chants,
under the ***shehnai*** music
flooding our bed like the molten moon.
Fire, too, his eyes, his touch.
His breath a whispered fire. And my *sari*
spilled on the floor that volcano night
redgashed, a tide of lava.

2. The day after the wedding
they took off my jewelry, weighed it.
When it came up short
of my father's promise,
they looked at me.
Their eyes glowed pale as coals.

I wrote my father, but I knew already.
The last cow sold,
two sisters left to marry off.
There was no more for my dowry.
They got rid of the servant
who broke coals for the kitchen,

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put me to work in that room, windowless,
where slabs lay piled
black on black dust.
Fire in the chest,
each indrawn breath a stabbing flame
as I strained to swing the hammer.

I wrote once more,
again knowing the reply.
If I left my husband's home
the family name would be black,
my sisters left unwed.
I did not write again.
Fire deep in the empty belly,
lying on the dark bedroom floor,
touching my wet face,
not knowing blood from tears.

Had I died,
he could have married again,
a good wife,
one with a dowry.
But though they prayed,
though we all prayed,
I did not die.

3. I saw them bring the kerosene last night
under the thin crescent
of the failing moon.
They hid the tins
in the women's house, where we spend
the defiled days each month.
They will do it next week
when it is my time,
the dark time of my blood.

I know what happens.
Last month I saw the body
of the night-watchman's new wife.
They gave her a grand funeral,
a hundred guests.
But under the piled jasmines,
the golden sandalpaste,
was the indecent gash of pink,
the skin crisped away,
the smell of charred flesh,

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unmistakable,
lodging deep in my belly.
I smell it as I wait.

Did they hold her down, struggling,
oozing the dark oily stain?
Did they silence her cries,
rough hand clamping across lips,
so the only sounds
were the sharp rasp of a match
and the quick blue hiss of fire
leaping in a night turned sudden red.

Sudha's Story (Pgs 45-49)

1. He saw her first at the Festival.
Flaming in scarlet silk
she danced the ***Tillana***
unfaltering. The ***tabla*** played faster.
Her braid whipped the air,
black lightning, as she spun. Her feet
were a blur of light. The people
could not stop clapping.

He sent word through the matchmaker.
Her parents were delighted. An officer
at Delhi, and she a small-town girl,
not even out of college. They sold
the village home for a grand
wedding. All the relatives came.

In the bride-bedroom
he asked her to dance.
As she swayed, arms raised,
In the love dance of Radha,
he turned her to him, wound the braid
around her throat.
From now on, you dance
only for me.
His lips kissed shut
the surprise in her eyes.

2. On the honeymoon at the Taj Mahal,
he laughed at her delight
in the translucent tombs
and pulled her close. But at night
his fingers tightened on her naked shoulders.

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I saw how you looked at the guide,
how you smiled.
Next day he took her home.

He told her to put away her textbooks.
He knew what went on in college.
All those young women
flirting with men.
Not my wife.

Each morning, leaving for work,
he locked her in. All day
she walked the large house, room
by room by room. Leaned her head
against the windowbars to cool the burn.
Evenings, he brought gifts --
a new ***sari***, perfume --
made her wear them to bed.

Her parents' letters were full of praise.
A promotion already, such
a generous husband, all the relatives
are dying of envy. She crushed
them in her fists, did not reply.

4NG Fanatics

Nights she dreamed of escape, body
swinging limp-necked on a rope
from a huge hook in the ceiling.
when she woke, the ceiling
stretched above her, endless,
always empty.

3. When he found her throwing up,
mornings, he laughed and crushed
her to his chest. Now my mark's
on you, in you, bearing my name.
He filled her nightstand with vitamins,
took her to the best doctors.
Let her sleep alone. Her belly
rounded, pulsed in a silver haze.
Days and nights spun away.
Until he flung the test results
in her face. *This isn't*
my child. No one in my family
fathered girl-children, ever. Tell me who
you slept with, who.
He left her on the floor.

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The crack of the door-bolt
ricocheted a long time in her skull.

That night the tonic tasted strange.
She woke retching,
doubled with cramps. Pain
jabbed at her belly
like broken Glass. Poison,
she thought, then felt the blood,
its thin sticky flow.
He watched from the door, eyes
like dead moons. Next day
he sent her parents
a regret telegram.

When his sleeping breath rasped
the dark, she stole to his bedroom door,
bolted it from outside. Poured
the cooking kerosene.
From her wedding-trunk, she shook out
her dance costume: gold anklets,
red silk. The flames took
the curtains and chairs,

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moved their mouths along the carpet.
She began the ***Nataraja***,
dance for the world's burning end.

My right foot balances
on a wheel of fire.
I swing the left across
the trembling air.
My palm holds up the sky,
which will fall
when I turn my wrist. The drums
die away. In the black quiet,
only the flames.
blood streaked, they whisper to me
in my daughter's voice.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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4H6 Fanatics

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier - *Sudha's Story only*
MN State Qualifier – *As a collection*

Glossary of terms

Godhuli: *Twilight, dusk, or gloaming, referring to the evening time when cows return home, raising dust; it's pronounced go-dhoo-lee, with emphasis on the middle syllable. A compound of Sanskrit words: go (cow) + dhūli (dust)*

sheora: *refers to a genus of resinous timber trees (like Red Lauan); pronunciation varies, often sounding like SHOH-ra (for the tree) or potentially she-OH-ra (as a name variant)*

dhoti: *a traditional garment for men in South Asia, a long unstitched cloth (often cotton) wrapped around the waist and legs, resembling loose trousers, worn for daily wear, cultural events, and religious occasions, symbolizing purity. Pronounced DOH-tee.*

brahmin: *refers to the highest priestly caste in Hinduism, traditionally teachers and spiritual leaders. Pronounced bra:mən*

shehnai: *a traditional South Asian double-reed woodwind instrument, similar to an oboe, known for its auspicious, melodic sound, often used at weddings and in Indian classical music, symbolizing joy and good fortune. Pronounced "shah-NYE"*

Tillana: *a fast, rhythmic in South Indian music and dance, known for its joyous feel, often representing a dance of happiness; it's pronounced "thil-LAA-naa"*

tabla: *a pair of small Indian hand drums, central to Indian classical and popular music, where one drum (the dayan) is higher-pitched and the other (the bayan) is lower, played with hands and fingers to create complex rhythms. Pronounced TUH-blah*

sari: *a traditional South Asian women's garment, a long, unstitched piece of fabric draped around the body, with one end forming a skirt and the other a head or shoulder covering, pronounced SAH-ree*

Nataraja: *a Sanskrit term meaning "Lord of the Dance," combining Nata (dance) and Raja (king/lord). It refers to the Hindu god Shiva in his cosmic dancing form, symbolizing the cycle of creation, preservation, and destruction through his divine dance. Pronounced nah-tah-RAH-jah*

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